Beauty and the Beast:
Keeping Abreast of Sibling Rivalry
By Leslie Marinelli

LESLIE: **(Pgs 5-10)** I know it's wrong, but I can't help it. I have a favorite. I've read numerous books about siblings and birth order. All the experts agree that favoritism causes irreparable harm. And yet, no matter how hard I try to be fair and impartial, there is one I simply like better . . . She's prettier than her sister. There, I said it. She's also older, so we've had more time together to bond. Truth be told, she's simply near and dearer to my heart – and not just in terms of proximity. She's my left breast, and she's spectacular!

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to this slightly lopsided tale of two lifelong companions: a bold, beautiful overachiever and her moody younger sister clawing her way to catch-up.

*But *'There's no need to fear, Underdog is here!' (sing part of the theme) You see, even in the most dysfunctional families, balance can still be found . . . eventually.*

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LESLIE: Our family dynamic has always been a bit dysfunctional. My breast started to develop when I was 11-years-old. And no, that's not a *mistake*. I said ***breast . . .*** as in one. My left breast, "Mutt," began to bud a full year before "Jeff" on the right joined the puberty party in my Benetton sweater. And I'll never forget it, because my best friend's big sister Kelly told EVERYONE about my Lone Ranger. (Not unrelated: Kelly totally had it coming when we put that Nair in her shampoo.)

That was 1981. We were all singing about "Bette Davis Eyes," but I knew in my heart I would never be "Jessie's Girl" or experience "Endless Love" with only one hooter in my holster. A man with a "Slow Hand" sounded like a real catch according to The Pointer Sisters, but a girl with a slow breast? Not so much.

My chest ached constantly that summer . . . but mostly from sadness over my parents' recent divorce and having to spend July and August in the face-melting heat of Phoenix, Arizona, away from my mom, dog, and friends back east.

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So when I noticed a lump on the left side of my chest that July, I had no idea what to make of it. The only thing I new about boobs was that they came in pairs. This thing must have been a spider bite, or a hula-hoop injury, or a really low-hanging goiter.

But when the soreness persisted, I decided to take matters into my own hands. Every time I went into the bathroom, I would frantically perform 2-3 sets of the "I must, I must, I must increase my bust" move . . . ***but only with my right arm.*** Maybe I could give my lagging right breast a jump start and it could catch up with the other one before I went back to school.

Naturally my dad and stepmom were very curious why I was spending so much time grunting in the powder room that summer.

STEPMOM: *(knocking on the bathroom door)* Honey, are you OK in there? You sound like you're in pain. Are you eating enough fruit?

FATHER: You know, when I was a kid, my Bubbie would line us all up on Sunday nights and make each of us swallow a spoonful of cod liver oil.

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LESLIE: "I'm fine," I'd grunt between reps. "I'll be out in a minute." I'd emerge moments later – sweaty, breathless, right bicep bulging . . .

"Oh! Of course!" They nodded. There was only one other reason a kid that age would spend so much time behind a locked bathroom door. After that, they gave me a wide berth . . . and told me to wash my hands a lot. Next thing I knew, my stepmom bought me a copy of *Our Bodies, Ourselves.* I missed my mom.

My fascinating new book kept me busy though, as did exercising my right arm multiple times a day. By the end of the summer, I could properly diagnose 12 different venereal diseases and lift a car off a toddler with my left arm tied behind by back.

Surprisingly, having half an upper body like Lou Ferrigno did not nudge my other breast into existence. I returned home to Pittsburgh that August with a heavy heart and a rogue breast bud camouflaged by a "Wouldn't you like to be a Pepper too?" t-shirt

I disguised my embarrassing deformity to the best of my 6th grade ability. Luckily for me, ruffled prairie

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blouses and denim vests were all the rage in the early '80s, so it really wasn't that hard to hid from most people . . . excepts for that b**** Kelly with the chemical burns on her scalp.

About a year later, my right breast arrived on the scene, but she was definitely the ugly stepsister to my first-born favorite – just the slightest big smaller, and never quite as ample – with a lazy eye and a limp, if I'm being honest. To this day, sometimes I catch a glimpse of her and fully expect to hear her quoting Igor from *Young Frankenstein*: "What hump?"

By the time I got to high school, "Mutt and Jeff" had become more like "Marcia and Jan Brady." Sure, the were both flaxen-haired adolescent beauties, but we all know who got asked out on more dates.

Speaking of which, the first time I ever let a boy get to second base, it came as no surprise that he spent a lot more time hanging out with Marcia than Jan. I ***told*** her the lemon juice and the Afro wig were a bad idea. "Just be yourself, Jan! You'll make friends one day."

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Fortunately, things pretty much evened out with the girls once I went away to college and embraced an all-carb lifestyle. I still couldn't technically call them "the twins," unless they were fraternal, born over a year apart, and fathered by two different baby-daddies. But over time "Marcia and Jan" matured. Or maybe I matured. Actually I was probably just to busy playing beer pong and dancing in fraternities to notice or care. Either way, my 1.5 breasts and I learned to live together in relative harmony.

The three of us sure had some good times together in the 1990s. We frolicked on the topless beaches of Spain, cleanses our pores in the mud baths of Mexico, skinny dipped up and down the Jersy Shore, and even discovered our aptitude for foreign currency with the breast-to-Mardi-Gras-beads exchange rate in New Orleans.

Eventually I settled down and snagged a husband. Sure, he's legally blind without his contacts, and yes, he's right-handed, but so what? He's mine and he loves all of me unconditionally. In fact, he claims he's

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never noticed that one of my kumquats wears a back brace and speaks with lisp, but whatever.

Clearly, marital bliss agreed with us, until I became a mother for the first time. When my milk came in, no longer were my breast separate but unequal. They were finally one unified all-you-can-eat-buffet of womanly splendor. At last, their purpose in life would be realized and they would be judged not by their outward appearance, but by the content of their character.

What I didn't know was how difficult it would be. By the end of our first week together, my saber-toothed baby had managed to completely mangle my right nipple. "Marcia and Jan" morphed into "Beauty and The Beast." For the next two weeks, I could only nurse my son with my left udder and use a breast pump on the raw right side. "See? Even the baby has a favorite!" I lamented to my mother.

All three of my baby barracudas experienced the same passive-aggressive behavior from my right Milk Dud. And with every new bambino, "The Beast" seemed to

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grow more hideous and surly . . . just like Jan Brady when she had to start wearing glasses.

My breastfeeding days are long gone, but the sibling rivalry remains. Today, it's more about endurance – neither wants to get stepped on or mistaken for a genetically modified spaghetti squash. Little sister Jan has been gloating that she's finally better at something than her alpha-boob big sister Marcia: "The larger they are the harder they fall.

The important thing is that we are a family and we stick together. As different as they are, they're my girls and I'll love them until the day I die.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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** Underdog Theme Song can be found here*
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tEVsRLhet2k

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